Perspective from the US Bureau of Labor Statistics

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Data Management & Curation: Lessons from Government, Academia, and Research

3 June 2014

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BUREAU OF LABOR STATISTICS
U.S. DEPARTMENT OF LABOR

www.bls.gov

US Federal Statistical System

- Not like any other country
- 14 major US federal statistical agencies
  - BLS is one
- One subject matter
  - BLS – Labor economics
  - Exception – Census Bureau
    - Censuses
    - Federal household data collection

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BLS Mission

- The Bureau of Labor Statistics of the U.S. Department of Labor is **the principal Federal agency responsible for measuring labor market activity, working conditions, and price changes in the economy**. Its mission is to collect, analyze, and disseminate essential economic information to support public and private decision-making. As an independent statistical agency, BLS serves its diverse user communities by providing products and services that are objective, timely, accurate, and relevant.

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BLS Subject Areas

- Employment / Unemployment
- Prices
  - Consumer, Producer, Import / Export
- Wages / Benefits
- Workplace health
- Productivity
- Time use
- International comparisons

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BLS Data

- Most data –
  - Establishment surveys + Indexes
  - 2 Censuses: QCEW, CFOI
  - Other state programs: LAUS, MLS, SOII
  - Demographic surveys: CE, CPS, ATUS, NLS
- Publishing microdata
  - CE, NLS only
  - Census Bureau publishes CPS

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BLS Data

- Most data
  - Highly aggregated measures
  - Over 50 measure families
  - Thousands of series
  - Managed in LabStat database
- Other data
  - Published separately
  - Migrating to LabStat

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Data Availability

- Data
  - Tools on-line
    - Current – tools per subject area
      - One-screen (needs Java)
      - Multi-screen
    - Data Finder – one-stop shop - prototype
  - Text files
    - Formerly thru FTP, now HTTP
      - http://download.bls.gov/pub/time.series/
      - FTP not supported by all Federal agencies
      - Session limits

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Data Availability

- Common API
  - Access to LabStat database
  - JSON element set
- Data tables
  - HTML, PDF
    - All tables
  - Text, Excel, SAS, Stata
    - In addition

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Data Availability

- Metadata
  - Mapping files ~ Classifications
  - Definitions in BLS Taxonomy
  - SDMX
    - Not in wide use
    - BLS uses own data transfer to LabStat
    - IMF
      - National indicators
      - Metadata – SDDS
      - US project

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Data Availability

- Metadata
  - DDI
    - CE PUMS metadata
    - Plans / Needs Assessment

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Management

- Memory – cheaper
- Storage needs – going up
  - Data steadily increasing
  - Need for copies / Older snapshots
- Backups
  - Regular database backups
  - New pay structure
    - By the byte!

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Management

- Data files
  - Constantly growing
  - About 40M rows per year
    - Duplicate copies
      - Inside
      - Outside
    - 6GB new data each year
    - Does not include
      - Reports
      - Articles
      - Documentation

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Archiving

- By program office
  - Data to NARA (national archive)
  - General – records management
- Data libraries
  - No general policy
  - Public data
    - On web

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